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NEWSPAPER 27th November, 2017

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

48th WEEK



SYRIA... END GAME

UPSC CSE – GS III

GS III... TERRORISM



Learning Space

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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS ... DISCUSSION

27th NOVEMBER, 2017

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Endgame in Syria

Unless the peace dividend is visible soon, regression to anarchy cannot be ruled out



MAHESH SACHDEV

The seven-year-old Syrian conflict has recently seen a flurry of political activity toward a possible denouement. Following the defeat of the Islamic State (IS) at Abu Kamal, its last Syrian redoubt, military activities are being framed by the tenuous ceasefire between government-allied forces and motley rebel groups mostly confined to four de-escalation zones. Backed by support from the Russian Air Force, Iranian experts and fighters from Hezbollah militia of Lebanon, the former have an upper hand.

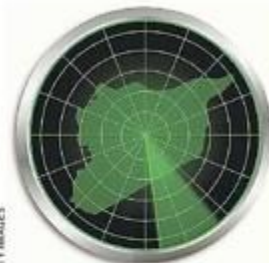
The rebels, with the solitary exception of Kurdish forces, have been losing ground, with their foreign patrons, mainly the U.S. and the Gulf Cooperation Council states, becoming more equivocal. The antagonists have been inconclusively engaged in the Astana Process, sponsored and guaranteed by Russia, Iran and Turkey, and the U.N.-sponsored Geneva Peace Talks. The conflict has taken a horrific toll: over a third of nearly 19 million Syrians have been displaced, nearly a fifth have sought

refuge outside the country, and over 400,000 are dead.

Russia's role

Russian President Vladimir Putin has pressed the military advantage in Syria to recently launch the search for a lasting political solution. His summit with Syrian President Bashar al-Assad at Sochi, Russia, on November 20 produced the broad outlines of a peace process even as the Syrian leader insisted on foreign non-interference. Following telephonic consultations with his U.S., Saudi, Egyptian and Israeli counterparts, Mr. Putin held a tripartite summit on November 22 with the Presidents of Iran and Turkey. They jointly announced the convening of a Syrian peace congress at Sochi to create a framework for national reconciliation. In tandem with the Russian initiatives, a Saudi-sponsored two-day meeting in Riyadh of over 140 Syrian rebels concluded yesterday with an agreement to field a unified delegation at the Geneva talks on November 28. They reportedly dropped their longstanding demand for the removal of President Assad which could help break the stalemate at the talks.

However, there are still formidable obstacles. First, the bloodletting and intense foreign involvement have created a bitter legacy to be overcome before meaningful



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negotiations can commence. Second, entrenched foreign interests often pursue divergent objectives. For instance, while Turkey demands the ouster of Mr. Assad and regards the Kurdish militia as terrorists, Russia and Iran hold opposite stands. Even though Russia and the U.S. have vowed to obliterate the IS, they hold opposite positions on the continuation of Mr. Assad. Similarly, though Israel and Saudi Arabia have their well-known differences, they are both apprehensive about Iranian gains in the Levant. Third, even as a need for a new Syrian Constitution is widely acknowledged, the prescriptions for a future polity range from a continuation of Ba'ath Arab nationalism (aka an Alawite-dominated military-security apparatus) to a Sunni Khilafat, and from a unitary republic to a loose confederation. At a different level, as Syria is the first instance of Russian mili-

tary intervention abroad since the end of the Cold War, it has provoked speculation about Mr. Putin's more muscular regional and global agenda. Last but not least, any peace package would necessarily require the injection of huge funds for reconstruction. Unless the peace dividend is visible soon, regression to anarchy cannot be ruled out.

Whiff of optimism

The best one can realistically hope for is a congruence of major players around the incipient political process, and progressive withdrawal of foreign military presence and interests. Left to themselves, exhausted and pauperised Syrians may come around to let bygones be bygones and create new paradigms for peaceful coexistence. There is some room for guarded optimism: Syrians have an ancient civilisation which has always been multi-ethnic and mostly serene. Further, their bitter experience provides a cautionary lesson. The current stalemate also shows the limits of those calling for regime change by force. Indeed, some of them may be bracing themselves for aftershocks as war-hardened fighters come home from Syria's killing fields. It may be better to de-escalate than risk Syria becoming a crucible for extremism.

At the regional level, the end-

game in Syria puts paid to a decade of the "Arab Spring" without any tangible gains. It also re-enforces the unshakable Arab faith in conspiracy theories of foreign powers being the ultimate arbiters of their destiny. Ironically, the Syrian conflict will reach its endgame in the centenary year of the Sykes-Picot Agreement and the infamous Balfour Declaration. As they say, the more things change, the more they stay the same.

A place for India

By keeping a low profile during the conflict, India has earned wider acceptability across the Syrian social spectrum. In normal times, the annual bilateral trade between the two countries was over half a billion dollars, with India enjoying a large trade surplus. In a post-conflict situation, India has a potential role in institution building and reconstruction. Among the possible initiatives to further our prospects could be extending an invitation to Mr. Assad for a return visit to India, holding a session of the joint commission and an Indian line of credit to finance our exports as well as projects and services.

Mahesh Sachdev, a retired Indian Ambassador with specialisation in West Asia, is President of Eco-Diplomacy and Strategies, a consultancy

2 Endgame in Syria - Mahesh Sachdev

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SYRIA CRISIS ... A BRIEF HISTORY

- 1 In March 2011, some teenagers were arrested when they painted some revolutionary slogans in a school in Daara
- 2 Protestors took to the streets in a big way and police opened fire killing several people
- 3 More street protests followed and Government used force to control them and several civilians were killed
- 4 Rebel brigades were formed to control the cities, towns and the countryside by acquiring arms. Here the rivalry of the Shias, Sunnis precipitated the crisis
- 5 As Bashar al-Assad belongs to Shiite Alawite sect, he was supported indirectly by Iran and some of the towns have majority population of Sunnis and Rebels (sunni groups) are supported by Saudi Arabia and others.
- 6 The long border of Turkey with Syria was used as conduit to the Rebel forces for arranging arms and ammunition
- 7 Seeing the political vacuum, IS spread its tentacles not only in Syria but also in adjacent Iraq



ISLAMIC STATE

GROUND REALITY NOW

- 1 Islamic State is on decline, now the ceasefire between Government and rebel forces is almost in force except in few locations.
- 2 The Government took the upper hand with the support from Russian Airforce, Iranian Experts and Hezbollah militia of Lebanon.

Islamic State is on retreat and at the same time, several rebel forces are losing ground. Over a third of nearly 19 million Syrians were displaced, a fifth of them taken refuge outside and around 4 lakh died in the conflict.





PEACE PROCESS AND VLADIMIR PUTIN



- 1 Mr. Putin held a Tripartite Summit on November 22 with the Presidents of Iran and Turkey.
- 2 Previously he had Summit with Syrian President Bashar al-Assad at Sochi, Russia, on November 20. A broad outline of a peace process was drawn.
- 3 Mr. Putin had telephonic consultations with his U.S., Saudi, Egyptian and Israeli counterparts
- 4 A Saudi sponsored two-day meeting in Riyadh of over 140 Syrian rebels was held.

Geneva talks are going to be held on November 28.



SYRIA AND CONTRADICTIONS



1 Excessive foreign involvement is the main problem.

2 Foreign interests are with divergent objectives.

3 Turkey wants Mr. Assad to go and it regards Kurdish militia as terrorists, where as Russia and Iran wants the opposite.

4 Israel and Saudi Arabia are now apprehensive about Iranian gains in the Levant Region.

5 Whether it can be unitary republic or a loose confederation is not clear.

6 Who will fund the huge reconstruction costs?



GROUP NO. 1



Bashar al-Assad
PRESIDENT, SYRIA



Vladimir Putin
PRESIDENT, RUSSIA



Hassan Rouhani
PRESIDENT, IRAN



HEZBOLLAH MILITIA



GROUP NO. 2

REBEL
FORCES



USA &
WEST

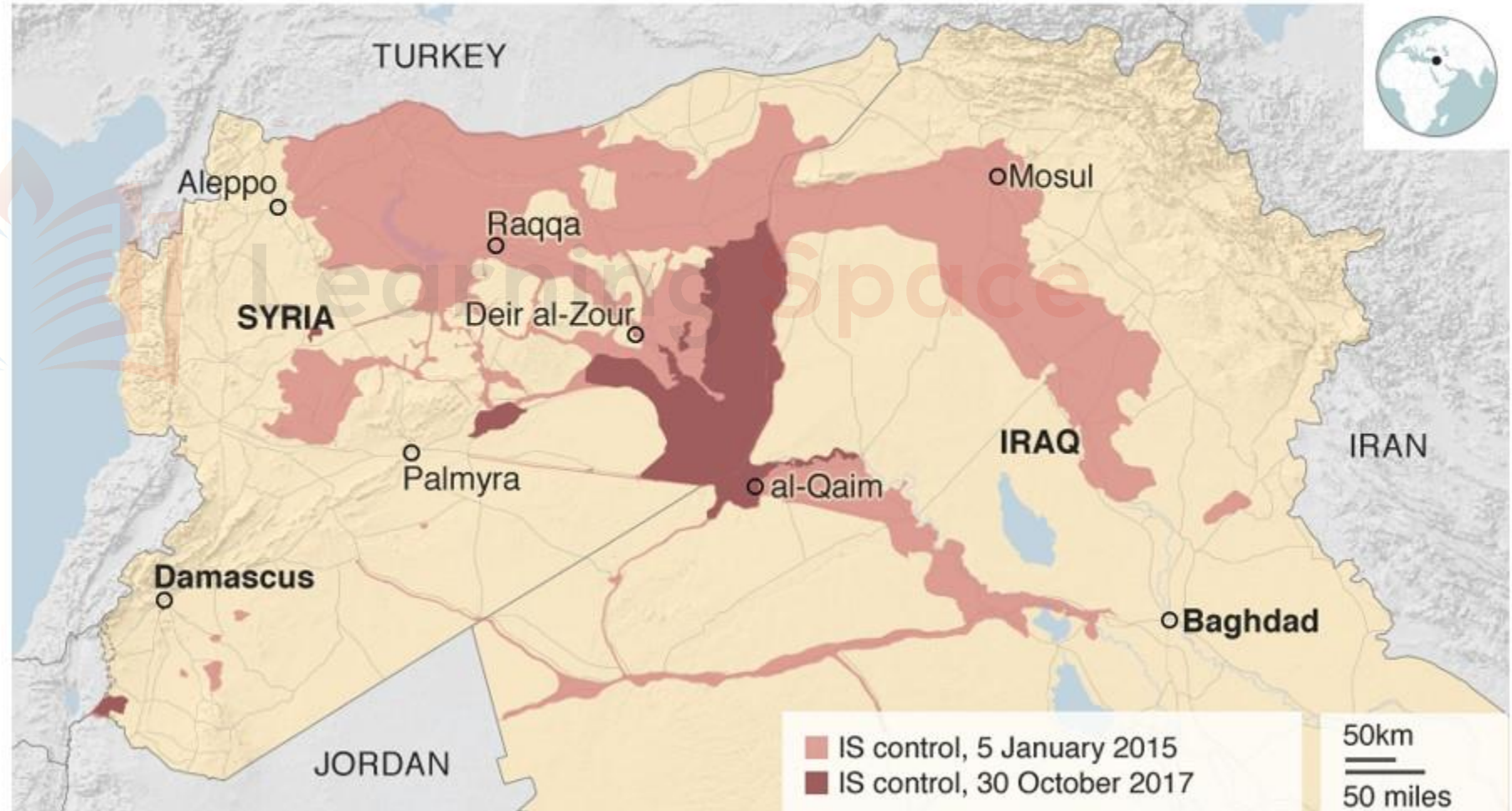
SAUDI ARABIA &
GULF ALLIES
(Sunni group)



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GROUP NO. 3

How much territory IS has lost since January 2015



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